



“We must find ways to deliver on-ground infrastructure and connectivity to millions at low cost”

SREEDHARA PANICKER SOMANATH

CHAIRPERSON, ISRO; AND SECRETARY IN THE DEPARTMENT OF SPACE, AT AN EVENT

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PAWAN GOENKA
CHAIRPERSON, IN-SPaCe

needed because there are no clear guidelines on FDI despite the sector’s enormous growth potential. “A liberal FDI policy in the space sector will definitely help in increasing the access to capital for the Indian spacetechn start-ups, which will open more opportunities for collaboration and growth in the sector in the coming years.”

In addition, India’s spacefaring potential is widely acknowledged globally because of the country’s demographic dividend and highly trained workforce. Elizebeth Varghese, People in Space-Leader at Deloitte and author of the best-seller *Stellar Singularity: Navigating the Spacefaring Economy*, says, “The new [space] policy will allow FDI in three different kinds of activities: satellite establishment and operations, launch vehicle and manufacturing, and subsystem manufacturing.” And this needs to be sped up through a supportive FDI mechanism, or else the country risks losing some of the benefits it has gained on the international stage.

“At one [point in] time, we had about a 2 per cent share of the international commercial space launch market. But then [Elon] Musk introduced his reusable Falcon 9 rocket, bringing down the cost of a commercial space launch significantly. India is no longer the cheapest in the market,” says Kaul.

In a first-of-its-kind move, Isro will transfer the technology of the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) it developed to the private sector to power low-cost launches, mitigating the high cost of its time-tested workhorse, the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV). The private sector will be the recipient of this major technology transfer through a competitive bidding process. Since Isro has spent years and hundreds of crores of rupees to develop various technologies, making them available to the private sector is a “big deal”. Goenka says this will be a “big enabler”. Reiterating that the progress wouldn’t have been achieved without the national space agency’s co-operation, he calls Isro “essential to the private space industry’s advancement.”

PROPELLING INDIAN ACTIVITY IN SPACE

Finally, a Space Activity Act may need to be enacted to bring Indian laws in line with global frameworks for space travel and exploration. In this regard, the government had put up a Space Activity Bill draft for public comments in 2017. However, it was soon forgotten until three years ago, when the government